

# Heartbeat

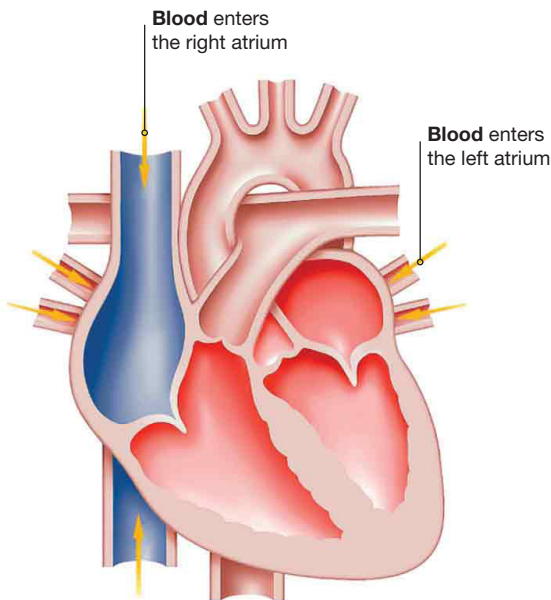
The fist-sized heart is an amazing double pump. Its right and left sides beat together to push blood to the lungs and body. In an average lifetime, the heart beats around 2.5 billion times without taking a break.

## Beating heart

Every heartbeat is made up of three stages. In the first stage, blood is drawn into the atria—the heart's upper chambers. In the second, blood is pushed into the ventricles below. In the final stage, blood is pushed out of the heart. Valves in the heart keep the blood flowing in one direction.



A baby's heart beats for the first time during the fourth week of pregnancy, when the baby is the size of a fingernail.



The **heart relaxes** and oxygen-poor blood flows into the right atrium, while oxygen-rich blood flows into the left atrium.